
Paper 3, Option 34.2:

Poverty, public health and the state in Britain, c1780–1939

Overview

This option comprises two parts: the *Aspects in breadth* focus on long-term changes and contextualise the *Aspects in depth*, which focus in detail on key episodes.

Together, the breadth and depth topics explore the ways in which the British state gradually, and not always successfully, became involved in taking on responsibility for people's health and welfare. This happened in reaction to a rapidly industrialising society, where thousands of people lived out their domestic and working lives in close proximity. The scale of the problem posed a question that is still asked today: where does responsibility for health and welfare lie – with the individual or with society?

Aspects in breadth: lives in peril – the health of the nation, c1780–1939	
Themes	Content
1 The impetus for public health reforms	• The impetus for change, c1780–1939: problems of public health created by industrialisation; impact of epidemics and reports on the state of towns and of increasing understanding about causes of disease (key development: the cholera epidemic 1832); the significance of advances in technology for improvements in the provision of systems for drainage and water supply. • Changes in the attitudes of public, press and parliament to public health issues, c1780–1939, and the reasons for them; the growth of the government's role in the nineteenth and early twentieth century.
2 Changes in public health	• The role of central government action and local initiatives in changes in public health provision c1780–1939: vaccinations, improvements in drainage and sewerage, improvements in water supply, the work of medical officers of health, provision of TB sanatoria and measures to improve the health of children (key developments: the Public Health Acts of 1848, 1858 and 1875, the Liberal government reforms, 1906–08). • The impact of the work of individuals in improving public health, c1780–1939: Edward Jenner, Edwin Chadwick, John Snow, Joseph Bazalgette and Marie Stopes.

Aspects in depth: poverty, the people and the law	
Key topics	Content
1 Paupers and pauperism, 1780–1832	• The organisation of the parish-based relief system; the problem of the 'able-bodied pauper'; outdoor relief systems – Speenhamland, Roundsman and the Labour Rate. • Indoor relief in poorhouses, workhouses and houses of correction; the impact of Gilbert's Act 1782 and the Sturges-Bourne Acts 1818 and 1819. • Pressures for change: financial and ideological arguments; the influence of Bentham's Utilitarianism.
2 Less eligibility: the Poor Law Amendment Act and its impact, 1832–47	• Reforming the Poor Law: the Royal Commission of Enquiry; aims of poor law policy; the Poor Law Amendment Act 1834; work of the Poor Law Commission; role of Chadwick. • The impact of the workhouse: the workhouse test and less eligibility; the workhouse regime and the continuation of outdoor relief. • The nature of opposition to the operation of new Poor Law, the roles of Oastler and Fielden; the significance of the Anti-Poor Law movement.
3 The government, self-help and charity, 1847–80	• Changing government control: significance of the Andover workhouse scandal; the Poor Law Board; the impact of the Parliamentary Reform Act 1867 on poor law policy; the Local Government Board. • The importance of charity and self-help in dealing with poverty: the Charity Organisation Society, Friendly Societies, trade unions and cooperatives. • The role of individuals in developing and challenging the prevailing orthodoxy: Smiles, Mayhew and Dickens.
4 Social and welfare reforms: pressure and action, 1880–1914	• Pressures for reform: the work of Booth, Seebohm Rowntree and the Fabian Society; the impact of Boer war recruitment statistics; the work of the Government Inter-Departmental Committee; the debate over national efficiency. • The significance of the Royal Commission on the Poor Laws, 1905–09 and of the majority and minority reports; the establishment of principles for welfare reform. • The impact of the Liberal government's reforms: old age pensions and National Insurance; the Trade Boards Act 1909 and the Labour Exchanges Act 1909.
5 Depression and the dole: poverty in the inter-war years, 1920–39	• The problem of poverty in the 1920s and 30s; the impact of the decline of heavy industry; the impact of the Wall Street Crash and the Depression. • The impact of the Jarrow March and hunger marches; the role of Ellen Wilkinson.